

Eames, Arnoldson, Sybil Sanderson, Zélie de Lussan, Frances Saville, Clementine de Vere, Scalchi, Mantelli, Brema, Tamagno, Maurel, Cremonini, Lassalle, Ancona, Campanari, Plançon—perhaps the most notable aggregation of stars ever assembled in opera.

"Afterward Madame Melba figured as super-star of the Damrosch-Ellis tours, and, when those ended, went to Oscar Hammerstein's Manhattan Opera House, to win new triumphs at a salary, she wrote in her memoirs, of \$3,000 a night. At the Manhattan she appeared with Bonci, Dalmores, Renaud, Ancona, Gilibert, and others."

Those who missed seeing or hearing Melba may cast a regretful glance over the writer's enthusiastic picture of her:

"There have been singers who were gifted with beauty of voice, and little beauty otherwise.

"Madame Melba offered everything.

"She had the living voice of her age. She was a beautiful woman. She had delightful social charm. Among the great artistes of the world she was truly a rare figure.

"Her simplicity, her freedom from posing, her frankness and cordiality were entirely charming. Born an Australian, but having led her art life in Paris, where she made her home, she adopted many French ways, but at heart she was always an Englishwoman, with a definite suggestion of English grit and solidity in everything she did and said.

"She was tall, with a rounded, supple figure, which came as close to the feminine idea of perfection as any figure might. Her face was oval and regular, with clear, pale complexion and dark brown eyes, which had something of the Oriental in them."

Singers and students can not fail to read with profit the writer's analysis of Melba's vocal art:

"In Handel's time the composer adapted his rôles to the voices in his company. Doubtless some of the success of the amazing Faustina and Cuzzoni was due to this.

"Melba, however, had to take her operas as she found them, and achieve her fame by singing them in her own way. Her voice was of the full range needed for the colorature and light lyric rôles of the modern repertoire.

"It extended from B flat below the clef to the high F. The scale was beautifully equalized throughout, and there was not the slightest change in the quality from bottom to top. All the tones were forward, there was never even a suspicion of throatiness. The full, flowing and facile emission of the tones has never been surpassed, if matched, by any other singer of our time.

"The intonation was preeminent in its correctness; the singer was rarely in the smallest measure off pitch.

"The Melba attack was little short of marvelous. The term attack is not a good one. Melba indeed had no attack; she opened her mouth and a tone was in existence. It began without ictus, when she wished it to, and without betrayal of breathing. It simply was there.

"When she wished to make a bold attack, as in the trio of the last scene of 'Faust,' she made it with the clear silvery stroke of a bell. Her trill was ravishing. On the evening of her début at the Metropolitan, she sang in the cadenza of the mad scene a prodigiously long crescendo trill, which was not merely astonishing, but also beautiful.

"Her staccati were as firm, as well placed, and as musical as if they had been played on a piano. Her cantilena was flawless in smoothness and purity. She phrased with elegance and sound musicianship as well as with consideration for the import of the text.

"In short, her technique was such as to bring out completely the whole beauty of her voice and to enhance her delivery with all the graces of vocal art.

"She was not a singer of what is called 'dramatic' manner, tho not devoid of sentiment or the ability to express a gentle pathos. But her interpretative power was superficial.

"She conquered rather by the sensuous spell of the voice, by the brilliancy and fluency of her ornamentation, and the symmetrical lines of her delivery, than by the awakening of feeling in her hearers.

"Her limitations did not prevent her from undertaking a wide variety of rôles. Immediately after her first *Lucia*, she sang *Nedda*, *Semiramide*, *Juliette*, *Gilda*. Comment at the time was that she was deficient in sentiment in the last-named part.

"But it must be borne in mind that much more was expected of singers then than now, and that Madame Melba surprised her hearers in later rôles."

"The Road to Culture"

SOME PEOPLE ARE ON THE WRONG ROAD.

They have taken the route to sophistication by mistake.

Sophistication, in fact, is "the bane of present-day life."

It is something we take on in place of real culture, according to Prof. Charles Gray Shaw of New York University.

Sophistication is like sunburn that peels off but doesn't turn to tan. And the sophisticated man or woman, boy or girl, is a pest, in Professor Shaw's eyes. "They talk about electrons and glands, psychology and complexes, Einstein and Freud, but they only talk."

This may seem at first a severe indictment, yet Dr. Shaw is a genial man who has repeatedly been voted the most popular professor at the University, whose blue eyes twinkle even when he launches a home-thrust.

"His point of view is easy, civilized, and tolerant," says Elmer Roessner in *The Telegram* (New York). "He holds up a crystal globe, and says quietly, 'This is living.' Yet in doing so he takes nothing from the charm and mystery of it all."

This "crystal globe" is his latest book, "The Road to Culture" (Funk and Wagnalls) which, since its recent publication has made strides in the best-seller class.

Culture, once thought a luxury, is brought by Professor Shaw into the realm of necessities.

It is not a mere decoration of the mind, but a means of interpreting oneself to oneself. "Like many other things, the popular desire for culture has widened, and yet become more definite since the World War."

AND if you want a test, here it is: "Your culture is the awakening of your consciousness to the meanings and value of a life habitually taken for granted."

It does not consist in the number of things you know, either, but in the discrimination with which you regard such matters as art, poetry, music, literature in general, even the things not so definitely of the spirit, such as the multitude of interests and objects our mechanical civilization has thrust upon us.

To give an illustration of Professor Shaw's approach to a much-banded-about theme, we learn how the man, proud of his sophistication, may even miss the point of such useful discoveries as modern psychiatry, "which now recognizes that certain ills result from suppression of both the instinctive and the intellectual, of both sex and spiritual life."

Dr. Shaw quotes Dr. Anna Mills, a psychoanalyst, who suggests that "disease is often an uncarved statue or unwritten play." Thus:

"The goal of life is creativeness. The tremendous urge to express oneself fully, when it is unrealized, can not do anything but cause one to become sick," said she.

"A special example of this appeared in the case of a patient suffering from neuritis, which turned out to be an unwritten novel imprisoned within him. The practical conclusion which Dr. Mills drew was that such esthetic sufferers should seek a cure for their spiritual maladies in the creative work of poetry or painting.

"Now, this psychological situation may have obtained in the mind of Byron, who expresses the energies of a nervous organism in that flow of poetry which proceeded from him with such apparent ease. More definitely does this appear in the life of Goethe, who expresses the beautiful and tormenting nature of his genius when he said, through his *Torquato Tasso*, 'Some God gave me power to tell how I suffer.' The average person, however, seeking culture and desiring self-expression, need not fancy that he must descend to the depths of the nervous patient or ascend to the heights of the talented poet, to grant himself sufficient expression for the normal aspirations of the mind.

"The main thing to observe is that expression comes from within, and can assume due form, either in the creation of beauty through art and literature, or in the appreciation of such esthetic excellence in others."

In another passage Dr. Shaw brings into our daily life the laws that govern in the arts, employing "examples of the harmonious in our chaotic, almost seismic, existence." Without such harmonies, Dr. Shaw visions us going "mad in even greater proportion than at the present rate of insanity":

"One's motor-car, if well supplied with cylinders, soothes the nerves of one who is speed-mad on the highway or intent on annihilating so much space per day. Its music, like that of a monstrous metal humming-bird, hath charms to soothe the savage or civilized breast. The auto maker aims not to produce by the car a radio outfit, but the rhythmic movement of the engine is such as to engender a tonal balance, however monotonous.

"Travel by rail has long done this by means of the tactata played by the wheels upon the rails. Then, as if to work like an Eolian harp, the whole train, by piling up and breaking down large masses of air ahead, yields an organlike effect.

"The traveler may enjoy this primitive music or practical poetry in its raw form, or he may call upon the train, as it moves rail after rail, to accompany his recital of a poem.

"Indeed, some enthusiasts over present-day poetry as invited by mechanical clatter have gone so far as to suggest poetical possibilities in the periodic clanks of a flat wheel on a trolley-car. But these are only trivial examples of that rhythmic sense, which, whether in our natural or civilized states of mind can not be subdued.

"Had we not acquired this from nature, and adhered to it in civilization, the poet who lives upon our rhythmic sense would be even worse off than he is to-day."

FINALLY, to choose a practical hint, Dr. Shaw would make us all writers—for an audience of one, ourselves:

"One's own note-book is important as a human comedy.

"Such a personal work can show one how his culture can change natural respiration into the systematic breathing exercise of a Yogi, or make the course of life like a stream of consciousness.

"A diary should record one's own doings with the fidelity of a weather report on one's own skies. A blank book written up as Reminiscences can involve other people and public events. A journal can take on a more literary character by treating books in a personal way as friends.

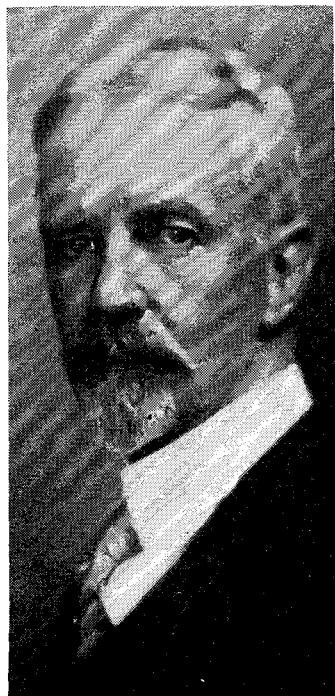
"The literary result may not be 'Pepys' Diary,' but the Pepys habit of recording personal reactions to life can form a pathway to culture, which is largely a consciousness of existence.

"The main thing is to cultivate active culture in the form of such incessant essays, whether they are to be syndicated or not. Such a graphic method will enable one to make culture, but not necessarily money, by writing.

"There are books designed for such a purpose, but often they are devoted to only the exceptional experiences in one's usual career. 'Plays I Have Seen' and 'Operas I Have Heard' are of this sort, and seem somewhat like a blank book for bridge scores or account books. 'A Line a Day' is a better model to follow, altho that 'line' should be understood liberally.

"A portable typewriter, while not the pocket size of pencil or pen, has the value of facilitating writing; then, the results achieved with lettered keys are more likely to impress one than does his handwriting. But, again, it is the intellectual habit of cognizing life as it passes by, which is the important factor in culture by writing.

"Anything which will help one to make these verbal snapshots is to be recommended. By following them, one can produce a 'John Doe—His Book.' . . . Handbooks and pocket portfolios suggest culture in a busy life, or reading as one runs. There is no commuter who, in the course of a business career, travels the equivalent of a trip around the world who can not likewise make the journey equipped with handbooks which will supply the art and history of the countries he may travel ideally as his daily train makes its shuttle-movements in the monotonous to-and-fro of an active life."



Prof. Charles Gray Shaw

Who makes culture a "necessity."

A Prize Love Letter

DO LOVE LETTERS seem silly in the eyes of others than the two most intimately concerned?

Is the exposure of them a sacrilege?

The Knickerbocker Press (Albany) is dubious on both these points while it reports a competition for a prize. The Browning letters are usually set up as the perfect examples, and sacrilege was often alleged when they were made public. But the publication of "The Andromeda of Wimpole Street" (Dutton's) and the consequent play, "The Barretts of Wimpole Street," acted by Katharine Cornell, have more or less silenced protests.

The Press speculates on the motives of the prize-giving:

"There is no denying that love letters are among the most popular forms of public reading matter, and more than one sober-minded newspaper reader will turn away from the important news of the day if challenged in an adjoining column by a plaintive billet-doux used as evidence in the latest heart-balm action.

"A London newspaper has recently capitalized on this world-wide love of love letters by offering a prize of \$500 for the best submitted to it. Many thousands were received, representing all sorts of sentimental tastes and viewpoints toward the grand passion.

"From the deluge it finally selected one that seems best to express the universal emotions of the lover. It was written by a woman, and even in cold newspaper type has eloquence, fineness, beauty of thought and deep sincerity, something of the enduring poetical quality, in fact, of the famous letters that passed between Robert Browning and Elizabeth Barrett.

"It is not apparent whether the motive of this London newspaper was to encourage the writing of love letters or to discourage it, for the majority proved to be of the 'mushy' sort that makes the irreverent giggle. Some of them, indeed, were penned by cynics

with no other thought than ridicule.

"Dorothy Dix would, no doubt, assure us that you can not tell a lover by his love letters. None the less, those of us with old-fashioned notions will be glad of this renewed evidence that there are still bundles of old letters tied with blue ribbon stored away in many attics."

The Cover

THOSE who know Ireland will recognize the veracity of Mr. Henry's "Spring in Wicklow"—the bare, blue mountains, the low-lying cottages, the windy sky. He has chosen one of the spots favored of trees, for Ireland, tho not treeless, gives in spots the impression of bareness. The interlacing branches in this picture form a beautiful pattern. The Hackett Gallery, New York, supplies this sketch:

"Paul Henry, R. H. A., was born in Belfast, Ireland. He first studied drawing and painting for a short time at the Belfast School of Art before going to Paris to work at 'Julien's' and the Ecole des Beaux Arts.

"After several years in Paris, he went to London, where he worked at portraiture, and black-and-white drawing for book illustration and the press.

"After being established in London for several years, he went on a holiday to the west of Ireland, and was so captivated by the country and the people that he decided to stay and work in Ireland.

"He has had many one-man shows in London, Oxford, Dublin, and Belfast. Has also exhibited in principal European exhibitions, as well as in Australia and Canada.

"Examples of his work in public galleries include pictures in the Mappin Art Gallery, Sheffield, England, and the Belfast Municipal Art Gallery."